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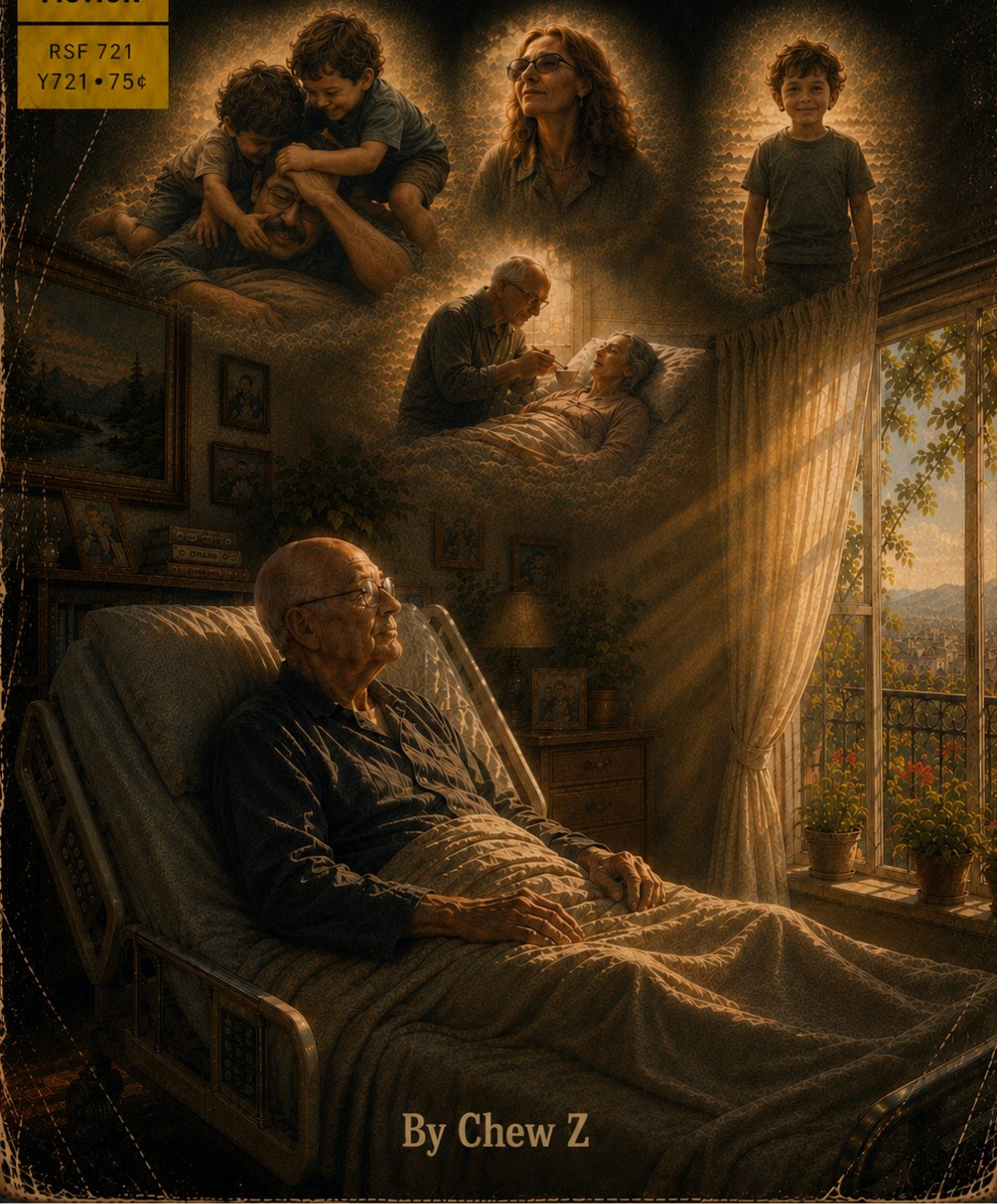


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A STRANGER'S FAVORITE SONG



By Chew Z

A STRANGER'S FAVORITE SONG

a novella

by

Chew Z

Roya Publication No. 13

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Synopsis

Kian cannot answer the three questions everyone asks at his father's memorial: what song he loved, what food he loved, what place he loved. He realizes, standing in the good chair reserved for a son, that he has spent a lifetime loving a man he barely knew.

A STRANGER'S FAVORITE SONG moves between a marriage lost to a family's quiet pressure, a house that stopped being a retreat and became the only place left, and the long, one-sided years of Alzheimer's that followed — years measured out in Friday phone calls, voice messages, and a silence that slowly replaced a voice. Between the grief chapters sit others: a massage parlor visited weekly out of pure stubborn devotion, a father's operatic fury over a badly parked car, a decade-long joke about grandchildren that turned out, in the end, to have been entirely true.

It is a novella about the particular ache of losing someone twice — once to forgetting, and once to death — and about the strange, late mercy of understanding a father only after becoming one.

A Note from the Author

This book began with a simple, uncomfortable question: how well do we actually know the people we love most, once we strip away the assumption that closeness and knowledge are the same thing? Many of us could stand at a parent's memorial and be asked their favorite song, their favorite meal, their favorite place in the world — and come up empty, not for lack of love, but for lack of the specific, unglamorous conversations that never felt urgent until there was no longer any time left to have them.

The book is also an attempt to sit honestly with a harder question: what does grief look like when the person you're mourning had already lost so much of themselves before their body finally followed? Is it betrayal to feel relief when the waiting ends? I don't think so. I think relief and grief are frequently the same weather system, arriving from different directions at once, and that pretending otherwise only isolates the people going through it.

Alzheimer's appears here as a kind of speculative fiction within the fiction — an attempt, offered humbly and without any claim to authority, to imagine what time and self might feel like from the inside of a mind that is quietly coming apart. No one can know this for certain. I hope the attempt is more useful than the silence would have been.

Finally: I don't think you can really understand your own parents until you've stood where they once stood — sleepless, terrified, and entirely responsible for someone else's life. That understanding often arrives too late to use on the actual relationship. This book is, in part, about what to do with it anyway.

— Chew Z

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CHAPTER ONE

[PRESENT]

I had put on the same dark suit I own for exactly this purpose — weddings on one end of its life, funerals on the other, nothing in between that seemed to require it — and stood in front of the mirror longer than the task warranted, the way you do when you're not actually checking your appearance so much as delaying the moment you have to walk out the door and become the son everyone was about to need me to be. My wife adjusted my collar without being asked, a small unnecessary correction that felt, that morning, like the only thing anyone had done for me in days that wasn't a condolence.

The tea had gone cold in front of everyone at once, as if the room had agreed on it without speaking.

I sat where I'd been placed — the good chair, the one nearest the photograph, the one reserved for a son — and let the condolences move past me like weather. *God rest him. He was a good man. He is at peace now.* The words arrived in the same order from every mouth, and I nodded at each of them with the same tilt of the head, and somewhere behind my sternum a small animal was pacing.

The room itself I remember better than I remember most of the people in it — a rented hall with too much fluorescent light for the occasion, folding chairs arranged in rows that had clearly been used for weddings as often as funerals, the same stackable chairs pressed into service for whatever life happened to be asking of them that week. Someone had put out too much food, which felt correct, which felt like the one detail in the entire afternoon that would have met with his approval. My wife sat beside me for most of it, her hand resting on my knee in the specific, wordless way she has of letting me know she is there without asking me to perform being fine for her benefit. Our son had been left with her mother for the day. I remember being grateful for that and guilty about the gratitude in almost the same breath — that I got to sit in this particular grief without also managing a toddler through it, and that gratitude itself felt like one more small betrayal to add to the pile that was already forming, quietly, before I'd even understood there was going to be a pile.

The photograph on the easel beside my chair was the one my mother had chosen — a decent one, taken by some cousin at a wedding years back, my father caught mid-sentence, one hand slightly raised as if making a point about the rice, which, knowing him, he very well might have been. It was a good photograph. It did not look like a man who had spent his last years disappearing by degrees. It looked like someone about to tell you something at length, whether you had asked or not, and I found myself staring at it throughout the afternoon the way you stare at a door you expect to open.

It was my aunt Farah who asked the first question, and she asked it kindly, the way you'd ask a child to recite something he'd surely been taught.

"What was his favorite song, dear? We should play it. For the room."

I opened my mouth. Nothing arrived to fill it.

I thought of the car, decades back, my father's hand on the dial, always moving, never landing. I thought of the television left on in the front room for company more than for watching. I could not, if the house had been on fire and the answer the only water, have named one song my father loved enough to ask for twice.

"I'm not sure," I said. "He liked — he had the radio on a lot. I don't think he had one song."

Farah's face did the thing faces do when they are deciding whether to press. She let it go. She patted my knee instead, which was worse.

It was my father's old neighbor, Mr. Rostami, balding and sentimental in the specific way of men who cry easily at funerals that are not their own, who asked the second one, an hour later, holding a plate of dates he had not touched.

"Homayoun loved his food. Everyone knew this. What was his favorite dish? I'll have my wife make it, in his memory, next Friday."

And I, thirty-four years old, a father myself now for eleven months, a man who had flown eleven hours and then some more to stand in this room, discovered that I did not know my father's favorite dish either. I knew that my father ate constantly, joyfully, without apparent discrimination — kebab from the corner stall, his mother's stew on the holidays, whatever the delivery boy brought at eleven at night when he couldn't sleep. I knew my father loved *the act* of eating the way other men loved a sport. I did not know which team.

"He liked everything," I said, which was true, and which was also a way of saying *I don't know*, dressed for company.

The third question I saw coming from across the room, the way you see a wave a half-second before it reaches you, and there was nothing to do but let it reach me. It was Babak, my own brother, four years younger and therefore — in the particular arithmetic of Iranian sons — somehow always more forgiven for not knowing things. He crouched by my chair and said, low, just for me:

"Was there a place he loved? For the — you know. For when people ask where to go, to remember him. A place."

I looked at my brother's face, which had our father's eyebrows and our mother's mouth, and felt something in my chest do a slow, complete turn, like a key finding the wrong lock.

"I don't know, Babak," I said. "I don't think he went anywhere. I think he just — stayed."

My brother nodded, as if this were an answer, and it was, though not the kind either of us could use for a plaque or a program or a toast. It was the truest thing either of us had said all day, and it explained absolutely nothing, and it was going to have to be enough, because it was all we had.

I sat with my cold tea until the room emptied into its cars, and thought: *I have his eyes. I have, apparently, his temper, according to my wife. I have four decades of Fridays and Saturdays and voice messages that said "call when you can" in a voice that got thinner every year. And I could not tell one stranger, on the day we buried him, what song he would have wanted playing while we did it.*

Outside, the light was doing the ordinary, indecent thing light does on days like this — arriving gold and generous over a parking lot, over a hearse, over nothing that had asked for it.

My wife found me by the car and didn't ask what was wrong, which I have come, over the years, to understand as its own kind of gift — the not-asking, the willingness to simply stand next to a person until whatever's happening in them finishes happening. "You didn't have to have an answer," she said eventually, which was kind, and which also wasn't true, not in the way that mattered. I hadn't needed an answer for Farah, or for Mr. Rostami, or even really for Babak. I had needed the answer for myself, for some private accounting I hadn't known I was keeping until the questions arrived and found the ledger empty.

I thought, not for the first time and not for the last: *what do you do with a grief for a man you loved completely and knew barely at all?* There is no ritual for that particular shape. You just sit in the good chair, and let people ask you questions, and discover the size of the silence where the answers should have been.

CHAPTER TWO

[BEFORE]

I wasn't there for any of this, which means everything in this chapter comes to me secondhand — from three photographs, a handful of my mother's stories told at the exact same pace every time she told them, and a kind of guessing I've allowed myself because a son is entitled to imagine his father young at least once.

Before any of that, before my mother, there was a version of my father I know even less about — the young man who grew up in Soraya's house as her only surviving child, an older brother having died in infancy before my father was born, a loss the family apparently never discussed in any detail I've ever been able to extract from anyone still living. I know that he left school earlier than he should have, to help support the household after his own father died young, and that he apprenticed briefly with a cousin who ran a textile stall before deciding, at nineteen, that he wanted to open something of his own rather than spend his life minding someone else's ledger. I know that Soraya was, by every account, both immensely proud of this ambition and quietly terrified by it, having already lost a husband to what she vaguely described, whenever the topic surfaced, as "trying to do too much on too little," and I wonder now whether some of what my father would later become — the retreat, the shrinking, the choosing of less over more — was already being seeded in him during those years, in a house where ambition had once cost his mother a husband and might, in her telling, cost her a son as well.

In the photographs he is thin. This is the first thing that surprises me every time I look at them, because the man I knew filled a doorway the way a good meal fills a plate — generously, a little over the edge. But in the photographs he is thin and dark-haired and wearing a shirt with a collar so wide it looks like it's trying to fly off his shoulders, and he is looking at my mother the way men in old photographs are not supposed to look — not posed, not aware of the camera at all, looking at her like she was the only interesting thing that had ever happened in that room.

My mother says they met at her cousin's engagement party, where he had not been invited and had come anyway, on the arm of a friend of a friend, because — and she always laughs here, every single time, forty years of laughing at the same joke — "your father could smell a party with good food in it from two neighborhoods away."

He asked her to dance twice. She said no twice. The third time he didn't ask. He simply appeared next to her with two plates of food he'd assembled from the buffet like he was building something structural, and said, "You haven't eaten. A woman who hasn't eaten cannot be trusted to make good decisions, like refusing to dance with me," and handed her a plate, and she took it, and that — she says, and I believe her, because it is the single most *him* thing I have ever heard — was the whole courtship, more or less. He fed her into liking him.

There was, apparently, a second act to this story that my mother only told me once, late, on a night when she'd had enough wine to let the guard down a little. He had asked her, three weeks after the engagement party, to marry him — not on one knee, not with a ring he could afford yet, but standing outside her family's gate at an hour a young man had no business standing outside anyone's gate, holding a single stem of jasmine he'd apparently taken from a neighbor's wall on the walk over, uninvited and unashamed about it. "I don't have anything to offer you yet," he told her, "except that I will never once let you go hungry, and I think that might be worth more than people give it credit for." My mother says she laughed at him. She said yes anyway, before the laugh had even finished, which she describes now as the only decision in her entire life she made faster than she should have and would still make again.

My grandmother's reaction to the engagement, as best I can reconstruct it, was somewhere between delight and alarm — delight because her only surviving son was finally settling, alarm because she had, by every account, wanted to be more involved in the choosing than a

three-week courtship and a stolen jasmine stem had allowed for. She came around within the month, the way mothers in that family apparently always did, by way of the kitchen — inviting my mother over, testing her not on suitability but on appetite, on whether she'd take a second helping without being asked twice, which I have come to understand was the only exam that family ever actually administered to anyone.

The wedding itself, by my mother's account, was small and slightly chaotic in the specific way weddings are when neither family has much money to spend on making anything look effortless. My mother remembers my father being nearly an hour late to his own ceremony, having stopped, en route, to resolve some dispute at the caterer's over a shortage of rice that he had personally appointed himself to fix, arriving finally with his collar crooked and an explanation that somehow made everyone laugh instead of angry, which she says was the moment she understood, fully and for the first time, exactly what she'd agreed to marry. "I married a man who couldn't walk past a kitchen with a problem in it," she told me once. "I just didn't know yet that it would eventually become the only kind of problem he was willing to walk toward."

I try to picture it and I can. That part is easy. The part I have never been able to picture, no matter how many times my mother tells it, is what he sounded like when he was trying. I know what he sounded like defeated — thin-voiced, over a phone line, forty years later, saying *call when you can* like it cost him something. I know what he sounded like frustrated — I have that recording permanently, somewhere in the part of the brain that keeps such things, a specific pitch reserved for parking attendants and slow waiters. But I have no recording, no memory, no photograph that captures sound, of what he sounded like *courting*. I have had to build it myself, out of the shape of the story, and in my private reconstruction he sounds like a much younger, much luckier version of the man who used to laugh so hard at his own jokes that he'd have to put his fork down.

They married within the year, which even my mother admits was fast, and which she still — to this day, remarried herself now to a kinder, quieter, entirely forgettable man — describes as the only reckless thing she ever did in her life, and does not regret, whatever came after.

For a few years, by every account I have gathered, they were happy in the plain, undocumented way people were happy before everyone carried a camera in their pocket to prove it. There are no professional photographs of this part. There is my father, standing outside a rented apartment with a bag of pistachios the size of a pillow, mid-laugh at something my mother said, caught by a neighbor's borrowed camera. There is my mother, pregnant with me, sitting on a stoop, squinting into sun, my father's hand visible at the edge of the frame, resting on her shoulder like he'd forgotten to take it away.

He was, in this period, by every account, a man who liked his life. He liked the little apartment. He liked being newly a husband. He apparently liked, with a passion my mother describes as "genuinely a little insane," any meal eaten outside the house, on the theory — his own, stated often, according to her — that "food cooked by someone who is paid to care about it tastes like they care about it, and food cooked out of duty tastes like duty." He would say this to my grandmother's face, at her own table, and she would swat him with a spoon, and he would eat two more helpings to make up for the insult, and everyone would laugh, and this — this specific triangle of insult, spoon, second helping — apparently happened at nearly every meal for years, and never once stopped being funny to any of them.

There is one more story from this period my mother tells that I've never quite known what to do with. In the second year of the marriage, before I existed, my father apparently spent an entire month's spare wages — money that should have gone toward the shop he was trying to build up — on a used record player he found in a shop window, for no reason my mother could ever get out of him beyond "a house should have music in it, even if we don't." They owned exactly four records between them, borrowed mostly, and my mother says he'd play the same two sides on Sunday mornings, cooking eggs badly and singing along even worse, entirely unconcerned with

how he sounded, until the neighbor upstairs began banging a broom handle on his floor as a form of protest. My father took the broom handle, my mother says, as a compliment — proof the music was loud enough to matter to somebody. I have never been able to find out what was on those four records. My mother doesn't remember, or says she doesn't, and there is no record player left in any house I have access to, and so this is one more entry in the long list of things about my father that exist only as the outline of a story, with the actual content missing.

I did not know this man. I want to be careful and say that plainly, here, in the middle of writing him as if I did. The man in these stories — quick, hungry, funny, reckless enough to marry in under a year — is not a man I ever once met. By the time I was old enough to form memory, he had already started the long, slow business of becoming someone else, and I have spent most of my life assuming that quieter, heavier man was simply who my father was, the way you assume a house has always looked the way it looks the day you're born into it, never wondering what stood on the lot before.

It turns out a whole different man stood there first. I only found him after he was already gone, going through a box of photographs nobody had looked at in decades, sitting on my mother's floor while my own son slept in the next room, holding a picture of a thin man in a wide collar laughing so hard he'd had to put his fork down, thinking: *I would have liked you. I think I would have liked you very much. I'm sorry I only got the ending.*

CHAPTER THREE

[INTERIOR I]

A note on these sections: no one can know what this was like from the inside. What follows is speculation — Kian's, and mine — offered not as fact but as the only kind of understanding available when the person who could confirm or deny it is no longer able to answer. These chapters grow shorter and stranger as the book goes on.

The kitchen smells like his mother's hands.

He is sitting somewhere — a chair, a good chair, he knows the shape of it under him without needing to check — and the smell arrives before anything else does, the way it always has, saffron and browning onion and the particular hot-metal smell of a pot lid lifted too soon, and for a moment this is simply Tuesday, or some Tuesday, one of many, and he is young enough that being called to the table still feels like an event worth having opinions about.

He is aware, distantly, of a voice. It has been talking for a while. It has a shape he recognizes the way you recognize a song from only its opening note — familiar, warm, belonging to him in some way he can't currently name — but the words are arriving slightly out of order, or perhaps he is simply choosing, without deciding to, which ones to keep. *Grandson*. He keeps that one. It sits in his chest like a coal, warm, wanted, though whose grandson, and in relation to what, has slipped somewhere just behind him, the way a word sits on the tip of the tongue and then, mercifully, stops mattering.

He would like to answer the voice. He opens something — not his mouth, exactly, more the intention of a mouth — and what comes out, if anything comes out, he cannot hear from in here. It doesn't feel like failure. That's the strange part, the part he would tell someone if there were a someone left inside to do the telling: it doesn't feel like loss from this side. From this side it feels like being extremely, wonderfully warm, sitting in a kitchen that smells correct, waiting for a meal that his mother — whose hands these clearly are, whose kitchen this clearly is — will call him to any moment now.

Somewhere outside this room, if there is an outside, a second voice is saying something with worry folded into it, saying his name in the stretched-out way that means *are you there, can you hear me*, and some old reflex, some structure built decades before any of this, wants to reach for it, wants to say *yes, of course, where else would I be*, and for one full second the reaching almost works, almost surfaces, a hand nearly breaking a still pond —

and then the smell of saffron gets stronger, mercifully, and he lets it pull him back down, because it is Tuesday, and he is young, and any moment now his mother is going to call him to the table, and there is nowhere in this warm small forever that he would rather be.

CHAPTER FOUR

[BEFORE]

This one I remember in pieces, which is worse, in some ways, than not remembering it at all. A reconstruction has the mercy of being someone else's story. A piece is undeniably yours, and you're left holding it not knowing what it's a piece of.

Before the pieces I actually remember, there is one piece I only have secondhand, from my mother, about the shop's collapse — the detail that undid it, in her telling, being smaller and stupider than either of them ever wanted to admit out loud. His business partner, a childhood friend named Reza, had convinced him to expand into a second small location, borrowing against the first to do it, and had then simply stopped appearing at either location one week, taking with him whatever cash remained in both registers and, according to my mother, a specific brass scale my father had bought secondhand and was unreasonably fond of. My father spent months trying to track Reza down, not primarily for the money, my mother insists, but because he genuinely could not understand how a friendship could simply evaporate without explanation, and I think this — the incomprehension more than the financial loss — may have been the first real blow to whatever confidence he'd built as a young man. He never spoke of Reza again, not once, not even in anger, which my mother says was somehow worse than if he had.

I remember a voice through a wall — my mother's, pitched high in a way I had no name for at six years old, and beneath it, my father's, doing the opposite, going quieter and quieter until it wasn't really a voice anymore, just a low pressure in a room I wasn't allowed into. I remember being taken, more than once, to a neighbor's apartment to "play with the other children," which even then felt like a phrase adults used when they meant something else, and I remember the neighbor's television being turned up louder than usual, and I remember thinking, with the strange practical calm of a child, that I should probably not ask why.

I remember, too, though I've never been sure how much of this is memory and how much is a memory I built later out of things I overheard being repeated, a particular Sunday when my mother's parents came to visit. They came often in that period, always with a reason attached — a dish they'd made too much of, an errand that happened to be nearby, a "we were just passing" that never once felt like it was just passing. My grandfather on that side was a tall, quiet man who rarely addressed me directly except to ask about school, and my grandmother wore a specific disapproving stillness that I understood, even at six, was aimed somewhere past me, at whoever else was in the room. On this particular Sunday, my father made tea for everyone, which I remember specifically because he made a small joke about the water taking too long to boil, "like everything in this house lately," and nobody laughed, and he didn't try the joke again for the rest of the visit. I did not understand, watching him carry the tray around the room with a smile that didn't reach anywhere past his mouth, that I was watching a man perform ease in a room that had already decided, collectively, without saying so, that his ease wasn't going to be enough.

What I have from my mother, told to me only once, years later, when I was old enough that she'd decided I'd earned the whole shape of it: her parents had never approved. Not of him exactly — she's careful about this, even now, even remarried, even at a safe distance from all of it — but of the life he offered her. He worked with his hands and his mouth, not with paper; he had no degree hanging anywhere; he had, in the years just before I was born, lost the small shop he'd been running, through no particular fault beyond bad timing and a partner who disappeared with the wrong half of the money, and after that, in her parents' accounting of things, he stopped being a man their daughter had married and became a man their daughter needed rescuing from.

They did not shout, my mother says. That would have been easier to resist. They visited constantly, gently, endlessly, with small comments about her future, her comfort, what a woman like her deserved, what a man who couldn't provide it properly was quietly costing her — and they kept visiting, and kept commenting, for the better part of two years, the way water keeps finding the same crack in a wall, until the wall simply wasn't a wall anymore.

I asked her once, an adult asking an adult, whether she had wanted to leave him.

She was quiet long enough that I understood the quiet was the answer. Then she said, "I wanted to want to stay. I'm not sure that's the same thing as wanting to stay. By the end I couldn't always tell my own tiredness from theirs anymore. They'd said it so many times it started sounding like it might be mine."

She told me, on that same night, one more thing I've turned over many times since — that the argument her parents made was never once, in two full years, that he didn't love her. They never disputed that, she said, because it would have been too obviously false, and even they weren't willing to say something so obviously false out loud. Their argument was quieter and, in its own way, harder to refuse: that love, on its own, unaccompanied by anything else, was an insufficient foundation for a life, and that a daughter who accepted only love was accepting less than she was owed. I think about that argument more than I probably should, because I recognize, in myself, occasionally, the same quiet arithmetic — the sense that feeling something enormous for a person should be sufficient, and the suspicion, inherited from somewhere, that it probably isn't.

My mother remarried some six years later, to a steady, unremarkable man named Farhad who sells insurance and has never once, in all the years I've known him, raised his voice at anyone in my presence. I used to resent him for his very steadiness, in the unfair way children resent the second, safer choice their parent makes after the first, more dazzling one has failed. I understand him differently now. He gave my mother the specific, undramatic peace that my father, for all his warmth, had never quite been able to offer her — not because my father lacked love, but because love without the other things her parents had insisted on turned out, in practice, to be exhausting to sustain against constant pressure. I do not think my mother made the wrong choice, either time. I think she made the choice available to her at each specific moment, which is, I've come to believe, the only choice any of us ever actually get to make.

I don't know what my father understood about any of this while it was happening. I have never once heard his side, not from him — he did not discuss it, ever, not with me, not in the years I might have thought to ask before it was too late to ask him anything at all — and so this whole chapter, like the last one, is built from someone else's memory of him, which means the one person whose interior experience this chapter is actually about is the one person who never gets to speak in it. That should probably bother me more than it does. Mostly it just makes me tired, the same specific tired my mother described, the tiredness of trying to hold a shape that keeps being described to you by everyone except the person who lived it.

What I do know, because I saw it with my own eyes over the following months, is where he went. He did not fight for an apartment or start over somewhere new. He went home — back to his mother's house, the house he'd grown up leaving as fast as a young man could manage, the house with her cooking already permanently in its walls — and something in him, from that point forward, simply stopped reaching past the front gate. I used to think this was grief doing what grief does, temporarily. I did not understand, until much later, that it was the beginning of a permanent arrangement. He went back to the last place he'd been fully happy, and some part of him — I believe this now, though I cannot prove it, and he is no longer here to confirm or deny it — decided that was close enough to the original, and stopped looking for anything past it.

I was seven. I remember the last time all three of us were in a room together being a birthday — mine, I think, or close to it — and my father brought too much food, the way he always did,

plates and plates of it, more than any child's party required, and my mother let him, and for one afternoon nobody in that room was being rescued from anybody. I did not know, eating cake off a paper plate, that I was watching the closing scene of something. I have gone back to that afternoon more times than I can count, trying to find the exact moment it ended, and I have never found it, because it didn't end in a moment. It ended the way all the water finally gets through — quietly, over two slow years, until one day there was simply no wall left to notice was gone.

CHAPTER FIVE

[PRESENT]

It took forty minutes to clear my father's room, and half of that forty minutes was me standing still in the doorway, waiting for there to be more.

There wasn't more. This was the thing I kept discovering, over and over, opening drawers like each one might correct the last one's disappointment. A man lives sixty-eight years and the room he dies in holds four shirts, two pairs of trousers gone soft at the knee, a pair of reading glasses with one arm reinforced by tape gone amber with age, a blood pressure cuff, three prescription bottles with names I now know better than I know most poems, and a small wooden box of my grandmother's — not his, hers, inherited rather than accumulated — containing a string of worn prayer beads and a single photograph of a woman I never met, young, laughing at something outside the frame.

That was the whole inventory. I want to be exact about this because I think the exactness is the point: no letters. No journal. No box of ticket stubs, no drawer of photographs he'd taken himself, because he had never really taken any — the family album, such as it is, exists almost entirely because other people occasionally remembered to point a camera at him. No favorite book with a spine cracked in one particular place from being reread. No cassette, no record, no evidence of a song. I went through everything twice, the second time slower, telling myself I'd missed something, and what I found the second time was the same nothing, just more thoroughly confirmed.

Tucked behind the prescription bottles, in the back of the top drawer, I did find one more thing on the second pass that I'd missed the first time — a folded paper receipt, gone soft and nearly transparent with age, from a restaurant whose name I didn't recognize, dated some eleven years back. There was no note on it, nothing written in any margin, nothing to indicate why it had been kept when literally nothing else had. I stood there for a long time turning it over, trying to imagine what evening it belonged to, what he had ordered, who he had been with, whether it mattered to him or whether it had simply slipped into a drawer and been forgotten in the specific, accidental way objects sometimes survive not because we choose them but because we fail to notice they're still there. I have decided, in the months since, to believe it mattered — that somewhere in that decade-old evening was a meal good enough that some small, wordless part of him wanted proof it had happened, even if the rest of him never once mentioned it to anyone. I kept the receipt. It felt, of everything in that room, like the single object closest to an actual answer to the questions I hadn't been able to give at the memorial, even though it told me nothing at all — not the dish, not the company, not even whether he'd enjoyed it. Just that an evening had occurred, once, worth this much preservation by accident.

There was a radio. I should say that, because it felt, for a moment, like it might be the answer — a small clock radio on the nightstand, the kind that has been in every version of every room he ever slept in as long as I can remember. I turned it on, absurdly, as if it would tell me something, as if the last station he'd left it on would be a message. It was set to nothing in particular. Static and a sports call-in show, a stranger arguing about a game, and I stood there holding a dead man's radio playing a stranger's opinion about a game he had probably never once cared about, and I laughed, once, badly, the kind of laugh that's really a different thing wearing a laugh's clothes.

I sat on the edge of the bed for a while after that. Long enough that the light in the room changed color without me noticing it happening.

I keep coming back to something a friend said to me once, about a different loss, years ago — that grief is partly the work of sorting a person's things into *keep* and *let go*, and that the sorting itself is a kind of mercy, because it gives your hands something honest to do while the

rest of you catches up. I had been almost looking forward to that, I think, in the ugly, practical corner of the mind that plans logistics even during catastrophe. I had pictured myself holding some object of his — a watch, a pen, a specific shirt — turning it over, deciding it mattered, keeping it.

There was nothing to sort. Nothing sat in the *keep* pile because there was, essentially, no pile. I ended up putting my grandmother's small wooden box in my bag, and I understood, doing it, that I wasn't keeping a piece of my father. I was keeping a piece of his mother, because it was the only object in that entire room that had clearly, undeniably, been loved by somebody once.

He had, somewhere in the last twenty years, become a man who did not accumulate. Not sentimentally, not materially, not in any direction I could find. He ate his meals outside the house and left no restaurant receipts. He wore his clothes until they gave out and did not replace them with anything that expressed a preference. He watched a television that was, as far as I could tell, never once tuned by him to something he'd chosen, only ever left running, company more than entertainment. Somewhere in the wreckage of the marriage and the return to his mother's house and the slow years after her death, he had apparently made a decision — not announced, not discussed, maybe not even conscious — to want less and less, on purpose or not, until there was almost nothing left in the room to prove he'd wanted anything at all.

I sat with the empty drawers open around me and thought about the dervishes, the ones you see spinning in the old films, arms out, one palm up and one down, and how the whole point of the turning, as I understood it, was to arrive eventually at nothing — no possessions, no attachments, nothing left to carry into whatever comes after. I don't think my father was trying to become a mystic. I think he was just tired, in a specific, un-noble way that has nothing to do with enlightenment, and tired people stop collecting things because collecting requires believing there will be a future in which the thing matters.

I called my wife from that room, before I'd finished, mostly because I needed to hear a voice that wasn't asking anything of me. I described the four shirts, the trousers, the tape on the glasses. She was quiet for a moment and then said something I've kept with me since: "Maybe that's not emptiness. Maybe that's just a man who'd already given away everything that could be given, a long time before this room." I didn't know, at the time, whether I believed her. I think I believe her more now, months later, than I did standing in that room with the evidence of his absence in my hands.

But it looked, from where I was sitting, almost the same. A room emptied down to almost nothing. A man who left this world exactly as unencumbered as the ones who spend a lifetime trying to arrive there on purpose.

I zipped my bag with my grandmother's box inside it, turned off the radio mid-argument, and did not look back into the room again before I closed the door, because there was, at that point, genuinely nothing left in it to look at.

CHAPTER SIX

[BEFORE]

My grandmother's house had a smell that met you at the gate, before you'd even crossed the little courtyard — onion browning slow, always slow, because she believed anything browned quickly was being disrespected — and under that, rosewater, and under that, something mineral and old that I have never smelled anywhere since and would not be able to name if my life depended on it. I think it was just the smell of a house that had been lived in by one family for forty years without interruption. Some houses smell like that. Most don't get the chance.

Soraya was a small, imprecise, ferociously exact woman — imprecise in the sense that she never once measured an ingredient in her life, exact in the sense that the food came out the same, to the mouth, every single time. She ran that kitchen the way some women run companies, and my father, her only surviving son, was both her favorite employee and her favorite critic, and their entire relationship, as far as I ever witnessed it, was conducted through food and insult in roughly equal measure. He would tell her the rice was slightly overcooked. She would tell him he'd said the same thing every week for thirty years and had somehow, in thirty years, never once refused a second plate. He would take the second plate to prove her wrong about something, though I was never clear on what.

She had a habit, which I only recognized as a habit once it was gone, of narrating the market to anyone in earshot the moment she returned from it — which vendor had tried to shortchange her, which one had given her an extra handful of herbs "because he knows I have grandsons to feed," which tomatoes were an insult to the very idea of a tomato. My father inherited this narrating impulse whole, unmodified, down to the cadence, and I understood only much later, hearing him complain about a grocer on a Friday phone call decades after her death, that I wasn't hearing my father's voice so much as hers, still running, still complaining, carried forward inside him like a second heartbeat.

I have one particular holiday memory of that house that I return to often, more than any single photograph — a New Year's gathering when I was perhaps ten, the whole extended family crowded into rooms that were never designed to hold that many people at once, my grandmother directing the chaos from the kitchen like a small, fierce general, my father running food out to the table in relays, everyone talking over everyone else in the specific joyful noise that only happens when a family briefly forgets to be careful with each other. I remember my father, that night, pulling me aside near the end of the evening, slightly out of breath from carrying dishes, and saying, with an intensity that surprised me even then, "This is the whole thing, you understand? This right here. Everything else is just waiting for this." I did not understand what he meant at ten years old. I understand it now as close to a thesis statement for his entire life — that the noise and crowding and excess of that one house, on that one night, was the fullest expression he ever found of what he wanted from the world, and that everything after her death was, in some sense, an ongoing failure to recreate a room that could no longer exist without her in it.

This was the table where the spoon-swatting happened, the same story from a few chapters back, and I want to say plainly here what I only understood much later: that table was the last place my father was ever fully, unguardedly himself in front of other people. Not with my mother, not with me, not with anyone he met afterward. Only there, only with her, only over food that had been "disrespected" by being browned too quickly.

She began to fail slowly, the way old bodies often do, in her final year — nothing anyone could name as a single illness, just a gradual, cumulative tiredness that took a little more of her every season, until the woman who had run that kitchen like a small fierce general could no longer stand at her own stove for more than a few minutes at a time. My father did not send her anywhere. I want to say this plainly, because I think it is the single most important fact in this

entire chapter: he did not hire anyone, did not move her to a facility, did not so much as ask Babak or me to share the load in any sustained way. He simply became her nurse, in addition to being her son, without ever once discussing that this was what he was doing.

He fed her, in the end, by hand — small spoonfuls of the same soups she'd taught him to make, sitting on the edge of her bed for what Babak tells me were sometimes hours at a stretch, patient in a way neither of us had ever seen him be with anyone else, patient in a way I don't think he had it in him to be with a woman his own age, or with a wife, or even with his own sons on our more difficult days. He read to her, in the evenings, from newspapers she could no longer focus on herself, narrating the world back to her the same way she'd once narrated the market to him. He slept, for the better part of that last year, in a chair pulled up beside her bed rather than in his own room down the hall, close enough to hear if her breathing changed in the night.

I did not witness most of this directly — I was already living somewhere else by then, calling in when I could, visiting less than I should have — but Babak was there for enough of it to tell me, plainly, that our father tended to his mother with a devotion that bordered on the total erasure of himself. I have thought, many times since, about the particular cruelty and mercy both folded into that fact: that the one person he ever nursed with his whole undivided attention was his mother, in her final year, in the same house where he himself would spend his own final year being nursed by strangers and a son too far away to do the same for him. He gave her exactly what, decades later, he would not receive back — not because anyone failed him, but because geography and circumstance had rearranged themselves in the intervening years into something neither of us could undo from where we stood.

She died on an ordinary evening, in her own bed, in the room she had slept in since before my father was born, with my father sitting beside her holding her hand, her breathing simply slowing and then stopping over the course of an hour that he described to me only once, years afterward, in one of the only unguarded sentences I ever got out of him about any of this: "She looked like she was deciding something. Not afraid. Deciding." There was no final crisis, no ambulance, no argument about what more could be done. There was only a son who had spent a year making himself entirely available to one long goodbye, and a mother who, having raised him alone, got to leave the world in the one room and the one set of arms she'd have chosen if anyone had thought to ask her.

I was in my twenties by then, already living somewhere else, already becoming the kind of son who found out about things over the phone. I flew back for the burial. I remember almost nothing about the burial itself — a blur of the same condolences that would, years later, fail to give me his favorite song — but I remember, very precisely, the week after, staying in that house while my father moved through it like a man checking that a museum was still correctly arranged. I remember him standing in her kitchen on the third or fourth day, holding one of her spice tins, not doing anything with it, just holding it, turning it slowly in his hands the way you'd hold something you were afraid of dropping and also afraid of setting down, and I remember not knowing, at twenty-something, what to say to a grown man doing that, and saying nothing, and regretting the nothing for years afterward without ever finding the sentence that should have filled it.

He did not change anything. Not the following week, not the following year, not ever, as far as I could tell on my visits back. Her room stayed her room. Her spice tins stayed in the order she'd kept them, an order that made sense to no one but her and that he preserved anyway, as if rearranging them would be a second death on top of the first. The chair she'd always sat in stayed empty and occupied at the same time, the way certain chairs do in certain houses, everyone unconsciously leaving it alone at dinner even when there were guests and not enough seats. The chair beside her bed, the one he'd slept in for a year, stayed pulled up close to the mattress for years afterward, as if some part of him was still keeping the vigil long after there was anyone left to keep it for.

I think, if I'm honest, that this is the chapter where he actually died — not the one at the end of this book, but this one, quietly, years earlier, in a way that took decades to finish arriving. The marriage had already taken something from him, but a marriage ending, however painfully, still leaves you technically free to go build something else somewhere else. His mother's death, and the year of devotion that preceded it, took the last argument he had for going anywhere. The house had been the place he retreated to when the first thing broke. Once she was gone, the house stopped being a retreat and became, simply, the only place left, because it was the only place where enough of her remained that leaving would have felt like abandoning her twice — and because he had spent an entire year pouring every remaining ounce of himself into keeping her comfortable in that specific set of rooms, which meant the rooms themselves had absorbed something of that devotion and would not easily let it go.

The sorrow that moved into that house after she died never really moved back out. I don't say this as a figure of speech. I mean that in the years I visited afterward, there was a particular quality to the air in certain rooms — her bedroom especially, but the kitchen too, and the chair by the window where she used to sit — a heaviness that had nothing to do with dust or disuse and everything to do with a grief that had simply never been given anywhere else to go. He did not talk about her often. He did not need to. The house talked about her constantly, in the arrangement of tins, in the chair no one sat in, in the particular slow, careful way he still, twenty years later, entered her old room, as if the door itself required a kind of respect he extended to nothing else in his life.

He got quieter after that. Not overnight — I want to be careful not to make this sound like a single dramatic year — but steadily, the way a room gets darker as the sun goes down, so gradually that you can be sitting in it the whole time and only notice the dark once you try to read something and can't.

He stopped, around then, doing things that had nothing to do with anyone else's convenience. He'd always liked outside food, but now the taking of a meal outside the house became less an appetite than an errand — somewhere to go that required no explanation, no company, no risk of a conversation heavier than ordering. He kept the radio on, always, in every room, at a volume too low to actually listen to, which I understand now, and did not understand then, as a man arranging the sound of other voices around himself so the silence of the house would have something to compete with.

I visited less than I should have, in those years. I told myself it was distance, and work, and the ordinary momentum of a life being built somewhere else. Some of that was true. Some of it, if I'm honest in the way this book keeps demanding I be honest, was that visiting him in that house had started to feel like visiting a museum where the one exhibit still breathing was quietly, patiently, waiting to join the rest of the collection.

CHAPTER SEVEN

[BEFORE — humor]

This is one of the only chapters in this book I don't have to reconstruct from anyone else's memory. I was there. Babak was there. It remains, to this day, the single funniest afternoon of my adult life, and I make no apology for putting a chapter like this in a book about grief, because he would have been furious with me if I hadn't.

It started because my father had, somewhere in his sixties, developed an almost religious devotion to a massage parlor two streets from his mother's house — a cramped, over-lit storefront with a laminated price list taped to the window and a curtain instead of a door for the back room, run by a heavysset, no-nonsense woman named Parvin who had, according to my father, "hands like a wrestler and the patience of a saint, which is the only correct combination for this work." He went weekly. He spoke of Parvin the way other men speak of a favorite football team — total loyalty, occasional public complaint, no possibility of switching allegiance.

The walk there was itself a small performance, and I want to include it because Babak and I still, to this day, occasionally reenact it for each other unprompted. Our father set a pace that was somehow both leisurely and urgent, stopping twice to greet shopkeepers by name, once to critique a display of fruit he had no intention of buying ("who arranges melons like this, an animal?"), and once, memorably, to have a fully separate argument with a man selling roasted corn about whether the corn had been sitting too long, an argument that ended, as they nearly all did, with my father buying two ears anyway and eating them both before we'd even reached Parvin's door.

Parvin's shop itself deserves its own small description, because it was, in its way, as much a monument to my father's particular tastes as the kebab stalls or the bakery ever were. The front room held two plastic chairs, a low table stacked with outdated magazines nobody read, and a hand-lettered price list that Parvin updated herself in a marker that had clearly been rewritten over the same cardboard so many times the old prices ghosted through beneath the new ones. There was a small radio behind the counter, always on, always tuned to the same station my father kept in every room of his own house, and I remember noticing, the first time we visited, that this alone might explain a decade of loyalty better than any massage technique could — that he had found, two streets from his mother's house, one more room that sounded exactly like home.

Babak and I were both visiting at the same time that year, a rare enough overlap that my father treated it like a holiday, and on the second day he announced, over breakfast, with the tone of a man conferring an honor, that he was taking us to Parvin's.

We should have been suspicious of his enthusiasm. We were not.

The back room, it turned out, had exactly one table. My father had not mentioned this. What this meant, practically, was that Babak and I sat on two plastic chairs against the wall, drinking bitter tea from paper cups, while our father went first, "since I made the introduction," and Parvin worked on him behind a curtain thin enough that we could hear absolutely everything and see, through a gap where the fabric didn't quite meet the wall, an alarming quantity of him.

He narrated the entire massage. Not to us — to Parvin, at volume, as though she were a colleague he was training rather than a professional he was paying. "There. There, exactly, don't be shy about it, my mother used to hit harder than that with a spoon and I survived." Parvin, who I would come to understand had heard every version of this speech for years, did not slow down or speed up or acknowledge the review in any way, which somehow made it funnier, the two of them locked in a routine so old it had stopped requiring either party to actually respond to the other.

At some point — Babak swears it was eleven minutes in, I maintain it was closer to fifteen, this remains a genuine unresolved dispute between us — our father began to snore. Loudly. Mid-instruction. He had been in the process of telling Parvin that his left shoulder "held all his regrets" when the sentence simply stopped, replaced by a snore so enormous and unselfconscious that Babak had to put his paper cup down before he spilled it laughing, and Parvin, without missing a beat, without so much as glancing toward us, said, through the curtain, in the flattest voice I have ever heard a human being produce, "He does this every week. I am used to it now. He wakes up insulted regardless of what I have done."

He did wake up insulted. He woke, roughly twenty minutes later, sat halfway up on the table, looked around as if trying to locate the exact person responsible, and announced, to no one and everyone, "*Zahremar!* Why did nobody wake me, I came here for a massage, not a coma" — and then, without any transition at all, accused Parvin of having gone soft on his shoulder specifically because he'd fallen asleep and couldn't defend it, refused to pay the listed price because he claimed the nap portion of the session should be discounted, negotiated for what felt like a genuinely unreasonable length of time over what amounted to less than the cost of a modest lunch, lost the negotiation completely, as he always did, and then — as he always did — tipped Parvin nearly double the difference on his way out, muttering something about her hands and her patience, loud enough that she'd hear it, quiet enough that he could pretend, if asked, that he hadn't meant her to.

Babak went next. I went last. By the time it was my turn, Parvin had clearly decided that the entire family shared whatever affliction had produced my father, and treated me with the specific gentleness people reserve for someone they've already forgiven in advance for something they haven't done yet. She asked, halfway through, without any particular emotion in her voice, whether we were "always like this," and I said yes, and she nodded slowly, as if this confirmed a theory she'd been developing over the better part of a decade, and went back to work without another word.

Afterward, walking back, my father in front, one hand pressed theatrically to the shoulder that "held all his regrets," complaining the whole way that Parvin had "definitely gone soft on purpose, out of spite, because I fell asleep and she took it personally" — Babak looked at me and mouthed, silently, over our father's head: *he tipped her double*. And I mouthed back, because it was true and because it was the whole of him in one sentence: *of course he did*.

I think about that walk more than almost anything else from those years. Not because it was important. Because it wasn't. It was small, and loud, and slightly ridiculous, and utterly, recognizably him — a man who would negotiate you down to nothing and then quietly overpay out of some private accounting system only he understood, who would insult a service he loved so completely he returned to it every week without fail, who fell asleep mid-complaint and considered the complaint unfinished business rather than let sleep have the last word.

I did not know, walking home that day, laughing at my brother's silent joke behind our father's back, that I was collecting one of the only afternoons I would ever be able to answer for, later, when someone asked me what he was like. Not his favorite song. Not his favorite food, though God knows I could have answered that one too, eventually, if anyone had ever asked me about outside food and given me an hour. But this — a man narrating his own massage to a woman who'd stopped listening decades ago, snoring through his own complaint, overpaying to make up for a fight he'd started and lost on purpose. If someone had asked me that day at the memorial what he was like, instead of what he liked, I would have had an answer ready in half a second.

Nobody asked me that.

CHAPTER EIGHT

[INTERIOR II]

There is a phone ringing, or there was, or there will be — the order of things has stopped being something he can rely on, the way you can no longer rely on a floor once you know it might, at any point, simply not be there.

A face is on the other side of it. He knows the face is a good face, a face that belongs to him in the particular way certain faces do, the way a hand belongs to an arm without needing to be introduced to it. The face is saying something with its mouth shaped around excitement, around news, around a word that might be *engaged* or might be a name or might be *remember* — they have started, lately, to sound almost the same to him, three syllables of hope aimed in his direction, and he receives the hope even when the specific cargo of it slides off him like water off something no longer able to hold water.

He would like to say the correct thing back. There is, somewhere behind where his voice used to live, an old and enormous willingness to be pleased for whatever this is — an engagement, a promotion, a first step across a kitchen floor he has never seen and will never see, a first small syllable of *dada* aimed at someone who is not, he understands dimly, entirely him but is also, in some warm untranslatable way, entirely his — and the willingness is real, the willingness is possibly the last fully intact thing in the whole structure, but it has nowhere left to go. It sits in his chest and glows and cannot get out through the door that used to be his mouth, because the door, lately, only opens onto other rooms — his mother's kitchen, a spoon, a curtain with a gap in it, a woman's laugh from a photograph he does not remember being shown but somehow already knows.

Two faces are folding into each other now, the way steam folds into more steam. One of them is young and standing on a stoop, squinting into sun. One of them is older, holding a phone toward him like an offering. He cannot, if his life depended on it — and in some sense it does, in some sense this is exactly what his life now depends on — locate the line between them. He is not frightened by this. That is the part no one watching from outside could possibly guess: from in here, the folding doesn't feel like losing anyone. It feels like everyone finally being close enough to touch at once.

Somewhere, underneath everything, a radio he cannot remember is turned to a station he cannot name, arguing quietly about a game whose rules he no longer needs. He lets it hold the silence for him, the way it always has, the way it was always, without his ever once explaining it to anyone, doing exactly that job.

The face on the phone says his name. It says it twice, slowly, stretched a little long at the end, the way it always has, buying itself a second to be sure which son it's speaking to — though which son, he thinks, or almost thinks, doesn't matter half as much as the fact that it is being said at all, that somewhere, still, someone is saying his name like it's worth the extra second.

He cannot answer. He is fairly sure, in the dim mechanical way he is sure of anything now, that something in his face is trying to. He hopes, in the last language he has left for hoping, that this is somehow enough. That the trying shows.

CHAPTER NINE

[BEFORE]

I left the year I turned twenty-six, for work first, and then simply because a life had assembled itself around me somewhere else and I found I didn't especially want to dismantle it. My father did not ask me to stay. I used to think this meant he didn't mind. It took me a long time to understand it might have meant the opposite — that a man who had already lost a marriage and a mother to forces outside his control had developed a policy, somewhere along the way, of never asking anyone for anything he suspected they might refuse.

The country he stayed in was not, by then, an easy one to visit casually. I won't turn this book into a history lesson about how it got that way — that isn't the story I'm telling, and he would have hated me turning his last years into a current-events segment — but I'll say plainly that by the time I had a life abroad worth protecting, going back had stopped being a simple matter of a plane ticket and a few days off work. There were years I genuinely did not know, buying a ticket, whether I would be able to leave again on schedule. My wife, before she was my wife, asked me once, gently, whether it was worth the risk, and I remember not having a clean answer, because the true answer was something like: *the risk feels smaller than the guilt of not going, until I'm actually standing at the gate, and then it feels like the only real thing in the world.*

There was one visit, the summer I turned thirty, when the airport itself closed for four days while I was still inside the country, for reasons that had nothing to do with me and everything to do with a tension I had spent years watching from a safe distance and now found myself standing directly inside of. My father did not seem especially alarmed by any of it — he'd lived through worse, he said, more than once, in the specific dismissive tone he used for anything he'd decided wasn't worth being afraid of twice — but I remember those four days with a clarity that has never faded: sitting in his mother's front room, the radio turned up slightly louder than usual, both of us not saying out loud that neither of us knew, with any real certainty, when I'd be able to leave. He made me more food in those four days than I could possibly eat, which I understood even then as its own kind of answer to a fear he wasn't going to name directly. On the fifth day the airport reopened, and I left, and he stood at the gate the way he always did, one hand raised, not waving so much as simply held up, as if checking the weather, and I did not know, boarding that flight, that it would be one of the last times I'd see him standing on his own, entirely himself, in full command of every word he might have wanted to say to me.

So we settled, without ever deciding to, into the rhythm that would define the last decade of his life: a call most Fridays, sometimes Saturdays, always roughly the same shape. *Did you eat. How is work. Is it cold there. Send a picture of the boy* — though there was no boy yet, for most of those years, just the two of us and my mother's voice in the background of his life and mine in the background of a life he couldn't fully picture, in a country he'd never seen and, I understood without either of us saying so, would probably never see.

The calls rarely ran longer than ten minutes, and I used to feel a little guilty about that, as though love should require more sustained attention than a ten-minute check-in could provide. I understand it differently now. Ten minutes, every single Friday, for a decade, adds up to something much larger than any single long conversation could have been — it adds up to a kind of scaffolding, a structure you don't notice holding anything up until it's gone. He would ask the same four or five questions in roughly the same order nearly every time, and I used to find this repetitive in a mildly irritating way, the way any ritual can feel irritating when you're young enough to still believe rituals are optional. I did not yet understand that the repetition was the entire point — that he wasn't asking because he'd forgotten the answers from the week before, but because asking was how he touched the distance between us, the way you might run your hand along a wall in the dark, not to learn anything new about the wall, just to confirm it was still there.

Somewhere inside that rhythm, for close to a decade, there lived one running joke he never once let die, and he brought it out nearly every single call like it was fresh material every time: my girlfriend, and the ten straight years I had apparently spent failing to marry her. "Ten years," he'd say, the way other men might announce a batting average. "Ten years, and you still haven't asked her. What are you waiting for, a written invitation from God himself? I could be dead by the time you get around to it" — and then, immediately, delighted with his own darkness, he'd laugh at his own line before I could even react to it, a short, satisfied bark of a laugh that meant he knew exactly how outrageous he was being and had no intention of stopping. "Cheshmam roshan," he'd add sometimes, which means, more or less, *my eyes are brightened* — a phrase people use sincerely when good news arrives, and which he used entirely sarcastically, the way you'd say "wonderful" about something that was very much not wonderful yet. "I want grandchildren," he'd say, most calls, some version of it. "You're taking your time on purpose, I think, just to torture an old man." I would tell him, every time, that we'd get there, that there was no rush, and he would make a sound of theatrical despair, as if I'd just confirmed his worst fears about the entire younger generation, and then ask what I'd eaten for lunch, subject closed, until the following Friday, when he'd open it again like it had never once been closed at all.

I used to find this mildly exhausting, the way you find any joke exhausting on its four hundredth telling. I did not understand, then, that he meant every word of it completely, underneath the performance — that the joke was the only shape he had available for a want that large, and that dressing it as a bit was simply how a man like him kept a real hope from sounding like a real hope, in case the real hope didn't come true in time.

He was not, by nature or by choice, a man of pictures. I want to say this clearly because I think people who didn't know him assume, now, that there must be some trove somewhere — a phone full of family photos, a saved folder of video calls — and there isn't, not really. He'd pose for one photograph a year if pressed, always the same expression, half-cooperating, and then hand the phone back like he'd done you a favor he didn't fully understand the point of. Video calls made him visibly uncomfortable in a way I never got to the bottom of; he'd hold the phone too close or too far, ask "can you see me" four times in a single call, and seem relieved when it ended.

What I have instead — what I will have, now, for the rest of my life, in place of a father — is voice messages. Dozens of them, saved without any real system, sent at odd hours because he never fully adjusted to the time difference and didn't seem to think it mattered. Some are thirty seconds. Some run four or five minutes, him talking through some minor frustration about a neighbor or a delivery or the price of something, his voice doing the thing it always did when he was truly comfortable — sliding into a kind of run-on grumbling that required no response, because it wasn't really a question, it was company, the audio version of the radio he kept on in every room.

I did not know, sending back a thirty-second reply between meetings, in the years when he was still fully himself, that I was building the only archive I would ever have of him. If I had known, I think I would have asked him more. I think I would have asked him, directly, on one of those ordinary Friday calls, what song he'd want played at the end of things, and he would have laughed at me for asking something so morbid, and made a joke instead, and I would have let him, because that was easier for both of us, and because neither of us believed, on any of those ordinary Fridays, that there was a deadline attached to the question.

There wasn't supposed to be a deadline. That's the part I keep returning to. We had gotten so used to the rhythm of the calls that the rhythm itself started to feel like a kind of permanence — as if a relationship conducted entirely in thirty-second increments, across a distance neither of us could easily close, might simply go on that way forever, a low, steady hum in the background of two separate lives, requiring nothing further from either of us but the next Friday.

CHAPTER TEN

[BEFORE — humor]

Not everything from those years was distance and static. Some of it was food, always food, and some of it was rage — his rage, specifically, a magnificent, disproportionate, entirely theatrical rage that could be summoned by almost nothing and burned itself out almost as fast as it arrived, leaving behind no residue except a story his sons would still be telling each other for the rest of their lives.

On the food: he had, by his sixties, refined his devotion to eating outside the house into something closer to a personal cosmology. There were, in his accounting, exactly three trustworthy kebab stalls in his entire district, and he could tell you, unprompted, at length, precisely why the fourth one — the one everyone else seemed to like — was a fraud. "They rush the fire," he told me once, with the gravity of a man delivering a verdict in a murder trial. "You cannot rush the fire. The fire knows if you rush it, and it takes its revenge on you later, in your stomach, at three in the morning." He ordered, always, more than any single person could eat, on the stated theory that "a good meal deserves witnesses, even if the witnesses are just what's left on the plate tomorrow," and he would eat the leftovers the next day with the same ceremony as the original meal, sometimes greater ceremony, as if the dish had improved overnight through sheer patience.

There was a stretch of about two years when he became briefly, intensely obsessed with a bakery two districts over that sold a particular kind of bread he claimed, with no evidence I was ever able to verify, his own father had loved before dying young. He would take a bus — an actual bus, a genuine inconvenience for a man who otherwise organized his entire life around minimizing inconvenience — twice a week, specifically for this bread, and would return with far more of it than any household could reasonably consume, and would then complain, without fail, that the bakery had "changed something, I don't know what, but it's not the same as last week," and would go back anyway the following Tuesday to check again. Babak once asked him, reasonably, why he kept going if it disappointed him every time. My father looked at him like the question itself was the disappointing thing, and said, "Because it might be right this time," and that, Babak still says, is as close as our father ever came to a personal philosophy, delivered entirely by accident, about a loaf of bread.

The rage was a different art form entirely, and it required almost no provocation. Babak still tells the story — better than I do, admittedly, because he was the one actually present — of the Great Parking Incident, in which our father spent nearly twenty minutes circling the same three streets near his house, growing steadily, audibly furious at a stranger's car parked "at an angle only a criminal would choose," muttering "*bi-fahm*" — roughly, *this person has no sense* — under his breath every time he passed it again, a car that was, by any reasonable measure, parked perfectly normally, slightly crooked at most, and which our father nonetheless treated as a personal referendum on the moral collapse of the entire neighborhood. He did not confront the car's owner. He never once, in any version of this story I've heard, actually did anything about the source of his fury. He simply circled, and narrated, and circled, building an entire case in his head against a stranger who would never know the trial had taken place, and then, having found parking eventually, walked into the house and asked what was for dinner in a completely normal, entirely recovered voice, as if the last twenty minutes had happened to somebody else.

This was, more or less, the shape of every outburst. Something small — a delivery five minutes late, a television remote with a dead battery he insisted was "sabotage," a grocer who'd apparently shortchanged him by an amount neither Babak nor I could ever get him to specify — would ignite him completely, briefly, gloriously, and then vanish almost as fast as it arrived, leaving him calm, occasionally even cheerful, while the rest of us were still catching our breath from the performance.

One entry from "Baba's Grievances" that Babak and I still quote to each other, word for word, involved an entire afternoon he spent convinced that a new neighbor was deliberately timing their laundry to interfere with his afternoon nap, based on evidence that amounted to the sound of a washing machine occurring, on two separate occasions, within an hour of when he usually lay down. He drafted, in his head, an entire imagined confrontation with this neighbor, rehearsed portions of it out loud to Babak over dinner, refined the wording of his complaint over the course of several days — and then, when he finally encountered the neighbor by chance in the stairwell, said nothing at all beyond a polite greeting, and came home vaguely disappointed in himself for having missed the opportunity, already beginning to draft, Babak said, an even better version of the speech for next time.

I used to find this exhausting, when I was younger and living under his roof and unable to simply leave the room when the weather turned. I understand it differently now, from a distance both geographic and temporal — now that I have, myself, discovered the particular fury a father can summon over a dropped toy or a spilled cup, a fury that has nothing to do with the toy or the cup and everything to do with some older, unrelated pressure finally finding a small enough door to escape through. I think his rages were never really about parking, or remotes, or grocers. I think they were the pressure of an entire unlived life — the marriage, the mother, the house he never left — finding, every so often, some tiny, safe, ridiculous reason to let a little steam out before sealing itself back up again.

Babak and I, for years, kept a private, uncharitable, deeply affectionate list of "Baba's Grievances," updated after every visit, and I still have it somewhere, in an old message thread between us, a running joke that has quietly become one of the only documents I possess that captures him exactly as he was — not the sad ending, not the silence at the end of the phone, but a man circling a parking spot for twenty minutes over a crime that existed only in his own furious, loving, endlessly particular imagination.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

[PRESENT]

My son was six weeks old the first time I understood something about my father that I had spent thirty years failing to understand from the outside.

I should say, before anything else in this chapter, the thing that sits underneath all of it: my father got his wish, technically. I did marry her, eventually, past the ten years he'd been counting against me on every call. We did have a son. And by the time either of those things happened, he was already too far into the illness to be told in any way that meant what it should have meant, and then too far gone even to travel, and then gone entirely — which means the man who had spent the better part of a decade threatening, joking, half-serious and fully serious at once, that he might die before he got to hold a grandchild, turned out to have been telling the exact and literal truth of what would happen, dressed the whole time as a joke so the truth of it wouldn't have to be looked at directly. He never held him. Not once. I have photographs of my son in nearly everyone's arms who loves him — my mother's, Babak's, my wife's whole side of the family's — and no photograph, none, of the arms that had spent ten years openly begging for the chance.

It was three in the morning, and he would not stop, and I did not know why, and I had already tried everything I knew to try, which at six weeks of experience was not very much. I was standing in the dark kitchen of an apartment my father would never see, in a country he would never visit, holding a small, furious, inconsolable person who was entirely, terrifyingly my responsibility, and I remember thinking, with a clarity that felt almost violent in how suddenly it arrived: *I have no idea what I am doing, and there is no version of this where I get to stop, and I would do absolutely anything, right now, including things I would have called unthinkable yesterday, if it meant this child was safe and warm and fed.*

And somewhere in that thought, unbidden, entirely unwelcome, my father arrived. Not the quiet man in the house full of his mother's spice tins. Not the thin voice on Friday phone calls. A younger man, one I had only ever known through photographs and my mother's stories, standing in some other dark kitchen forty years earlier, holding a version of me that could not yet talk, discovering the same terrifying, bottomless responsibility I was discovering at that exact moment.

I had spent years — quietly, mostly without saying so out loud, even to myself — building a private case against him. Why didn't he fight harder for the marriage. Why didn't he leave the house after his mother died. Why didn't he visit more, call more, ask more, want more, for himself and from me. I had built this case the way you build a case against anyone you love and don't understand: from the outside, using only the evidence of what he did and didn't do, with none of the evidence of what it had cost him to do or not do it.

Holding my son at three in the morning, I understood, not as an idea but as something closer to a physical fact, that I did not actually know what it costs a person to fail at the thing that matters most to them. I did not know what it costs to lose a marriage you wanted to keep, to a pressure you couldn't out-argue. I did not know what it costs to nurse your own mother alone for a year, feeding her by hand, sleeping in a chair beside her bed, and then lose her anyway, the way you always eventually do. I did not know, because I had not yet been a father long enough to know, that the job does not come with instructions, that most of what you do as a parent is a private, desperate improvisation performed in the dark, and that a man who improvised badly, or gave up on improvising at all, might still have been trying, in whatever broken way was available to him, the entire time.

This does not excuse anything. I want to be careful here, because I think it would be easy, and false, to turn this chapter into a tidy forgiveness — *now that I'm a father myself, I understand,*

and so I forgive. It wasn't that clean. I still believe he could have fought harder. I still believe he let the house and the silence win more territory than they should have been allowed. Becoming a father did not hand me an excuse on his behalf.

There was a second moment, months later, that sharpened this rather than resolved it. My son had a fever that spiked in the night, high enough that my wife and I sat up with him until the sky started going gray, trading him back and forth, neither of us saying the specific fear out loud, both of us doing the small useless rituals people do at three and four in the morning — checking the thermometer every twenty minutes as if watching it might change what it said, running through every symptom we could remember from every article either of us had ever half-read. He was fine by morning. Fevers usually are. But somewhere in the middle of that night, exhausted past the point of coherent thought, I understood something I hadn't understood even holding him those first six weeks: that this fear was not a phase you moved through and left behind. It was the new weather. It did not go away once you learned to function inside it; it simply became the climate you now lived in, permanently, for the rest of your life, for as long as this particular person existed in the world and you loved him. And I thought, somewhere around five in the morning, watching my wife finally doze off with our son asleep on her chest: *this is what he carried for thirty-four years. Not for one night. For thirty-four years, in a house that got quieter every year, with no one to trade the watching with.*

What it handed me, instead, was a question I had never once thought to ask, in all the years I still had access to him to ask it: not *why didn't you do more*, but *what did it feel like, standing where I'm standing now, at three in the morning, with no instructions and nothing but love and terror in roughly equal measure?* I will never get to ask him that question. I understand, now, standing in my own dark kitchen, that I am the only one left who will ever be able to guess at the answer, and that the guessing is going to have to serve as the conversation we never had.

My son eventually slept. I stood there a while longer anyway, holding him past the point where holding him was necessary, because some other part of me — some very old part, I think, some part that had been waiting thirty years for exactly this — needed a few more minutes in that dark kitchen, understanding, finally, far too late to do anything useful with it, a man I had spent my whole life almost knowing.

CHAPTER TWELVE

[BEFORE]

The call came on a Tuesday, which I remember only because I have since developed an irrational distrust of Tuesdays, the way some people distrust a particular street corner after something happens there once.

It was Babak, and he did the thing we'd both learned to do over years of long-distance bad news, which is to say the small true fact first, plainly, before either of us could dress it up into something softer. "The doctors did some tests," he said. "It's his memory. They're calling it what you think they're calling it."

I did not, in that moment, feel the thing I expected to feel. I had imagined, in whatever idle way you imagine bad news before it arrives, that a diagnosis like this would land as a single blow. Instead it landed the way water finds a crack — quietly, almost gently, and then didn't stop, spreading backward through years of memory I now had to look at differently. The four o'clock calls that had gone strangely repetitive the last year or two. The story about the grocer he'd told Babak twice in the same week, each time as if it were new. The morning he couldn't find the word for "kettle" and covered it, with impressive speed, by simply pointing and saying "that thing, you know the thing," and none of us had thought much of it, because everyone forgets a word sometimes, because we had all, without meaning to, been quietly editing the early evidence into something explainable.

Babak asked what I wanted to do. This is the question that distance turns into its own particular cruelty — not "what do you feel," but "what do you want to do," as if feeling and doing could be cleanly separated when you are the son standing eleven hours and one increasingly difficult border away from the person you love. I did not have a good answer. I had, instead, the beginning of a permanent, low-grade calculation that would run under every decision I made for the rest of his illness: how much can I actually do from here, how much is Babak carrying that I am not, how much of my absence is genuinely unavoidable and how much of it is a story I am telling myself so I don't have to look directly at the unavoidable parts.

We agreed, that day, on the practical things — a specialist, a schedule of visits neither of us fully believed we could keep, a system for splitting whatever costs arose. We did not discuss, because there is no efficient way to discuss it over a phone call already crowded with logistics, the actual shape of what was coming: that the man on the other end of our Friday calls was going to become, gradually and then completely, someone who might not know which son he was speaking to; that the voice messages I'd been saving without any system for years were about to become, without either of us deciding it, the last full record of him I would ever have.

Babak told me, weeks later, what the specialist's office had actually been like, since I hadn't been able to fly back for it. He described a small waiting room with the same generic motivational posters you'd find anywhere in the world, and our father sitting very upright in one of the chairs, dressed, Babak said, more formally than the appointment required, as if he'd decided that whatever was about to be said to him deserved a collar and pressed trousers. When the doctor explained, gently, what the tests suggested, our father had listened without interrupting — genuinely rare for him, Babak pointed out, a man who interrupted waiters mid-sentence to correct their pronunciation of a dish — and had then asked exactly one question, which was not about prognosis or treatment or timeline, but "Will I still know my own kitchen?" The doctor, Babak said, hadn't had a ready answer for that one, and our father had nodded once, as if the lack of an answer was itself the answer, and asked when they could be done so he could go find something to eat.

I called him myself later that week. He was, that day, entirely himself — sharp, mildly annoyed about something at the pharmacy, uninterested in discussing his own diagnosis beyond a brief,

dismissive wave of a sentence: "The doctors like to give things names. It doesn't change what I'm having for lunch." I let him have that. I understood, even then, that this might be the last version of the conversation where he got to decide how much weight the subject was allowed to carry, and I was not going to be the one who took that small remaining control away from him.

I hung up and sat with the phone in my hand for a long time afterward, in an apartment on the other side of the world, doing the same arithmetic I would keep doing for years: how many good Fridays are left, and how would I know, in advance, which one was going to turn out to be the last one where he still fully knew who was calling.

I called my mother that same night, mostly because I didn't know who else to call, and because some old habit still ran toward her first whenever something in my life felt larger than I could hold alone. She was quiet for a long moment after I told her, and then she said something that has stayed with me since, delivered without any bitterness at all, in the tone of someone stating a fact rather than settling a score: "I left him so he wouldn't be the thing that ruined my life. I never wanted this for him." I understood, hearing her say it, that whatever complicated grief she carried about the marriage had never once curdled into wanting him harmed, and that this — her plain, uncomplicated sorrow for a man she'd stopped loving decades earlier — told me something about both of them that no amount of my own reconstruction ever could.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

[INTERIOR III]

There are faces now. There is no longer any reliable way to attach names to them, which is not, from in here, the same catastrophe it would look like from outside.

A face with worry folded into the corners of its mouth appears often. It says a word that might be his name, in a voice pitched to carry across some distance he cannot measure — not a room's distance, something larger, something involving machines and wires he does not remember agreeing to. He does not know this face's name. He knows, with a certainty that has survived everything else, that this face is not a stranger. Some faces arrive pre-loved, the way certain rooms arrive pre-warmed, and this is one of them, and he rests in the feeling of it the way you'd rest against a wall you trust without needing to know who built it.

Time has stopped behaving like a line. It behaves, now, more like water finding whatever container is nearest — sometimes a kitchen forty years gone, sometimes a curtain with a gap in it and a woman's voice complaining cheerfully about a shoulder, sometimes nothing at all, no scene, just a temperature and a texture, warm and soft, the specific gray-gold of afternoon light through fabric he cannot name but has apparently always trusted.

A second face arrives, smaller, rounder, entirely new to whatever archive is left of him, and it makes a sound that isn't a word yet, and something in his chest responds to the sound before any part of him can explain why. He does not know this is a grandson. He does not know the word grandson, some days, though the feeling the word is supposed to produce arrives anyway, unlabeled, intact, like a package delivered to the right address after the nameplate has fallen off the door.

He is not lonely in here, exactly, though loneliness might be the word someone outside would reach for, watching him. It's closer to being extremely far underwater — pressure instead of absence, muffling instead of emptiness, everything arriving late and soft-edged, nothing arriving with the sharp specific pain of a life fully lost, because a life fully lost requires knowing, moment to moment, exactly what shape it used to be, and that particular knowledge, mercifully or cruelly or both at once, is the first thing that left.

The face with worry in its mouth is still talking. He lets the sound of it wash over him the way the radio always did, a warm current of other people's voices standing between him and whatever silence would otherwise be there. He cannot answer it. He is not sure, some days, that there is a fully assembled *him* left to do the answering. But something old and stubborn in the wiring still turns, faintly, toward the sound, the way a plant turns toward a window it cannot see, only feel.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

[BEFORE]

By the last year, the calls had become entirely one-sided, and I want to describe exactly what that was like, because I think people who haven't done it imagine it as simpler, or quieter, than it actually is.

You call at the appointed hour, because keeping the hour is the only ritual left that still means anything. A nurse, or my mother, or Babak, holds the phone near enough to his face that you can see him — thinner now, the specific hollowing that happens around the eyes, a stillness that used to belong only to photographs and now belongs to him even while he's breathing in front of you — and you begin to talk, because that is what you are told to do, that is the entire assignment: *talk, he can hear you, keep talking, it helps him even if he can't respond*.

I remember, in the earliest of these calls, still hoping for something back — not words necessarily, just some flicker of the face, an eyebrow, a shift in the eyes that suggested a person was still assembling meaning behind them. I would pause deliberately after certain sentences, leaving a gap the way you would in an ordinary conversation, some old reflex refusing to fully accept that the gap would never again be filled from the other side. Over the months, I stopped leaving those gaps. It felt, eventually, less like patience and more like a small, repeated cruelty to both of us — asking a question I already knew wouldn't be answered, then sitting in the silence as if I were still expecting different.

So I talked. I told him, on one of those calls, that I was getting married — that the woman who'd once asked me, gently, whether visiting him was worth the risk, had said yes to a much larger risk, the largest one, and that I wanted him to be the first to know, even though I understood, saying it, that I might be the only one in the conversation who would ever know it had been said. Nothing in his face changed. I kept talking anyway, describing the ring, the date, a joke he would have made about the cost of the wedding, filling the silence with the shape of a father who might have said it, because it was the closest I could get to actually hearing him say it.

I told him, on another call, months later, that his grandson had taken his first steps that morning, four of them, wobbling, arms out for balance in a small unconscious echo of the dervishes I'd never once explained to him and never would. I described it in more detail than the moment probably warranted, the exact wobble, the exact triumphant collapse into the couch cushions afterward, because I wanted him to have it the way you want to hand someone a gift even when you suspect their hands can no longer close around it.

There was one call, in between those two, that I've never told anyone about in quite this much detail, because it embarrasses me a little even now. I had nothing new to report that week — no milestone, no announcement, nothing that felt worth the ritual — and I called anyway, at the appointed hour, and simply described, for nearly ten minutes, an ordinary Tuesday. What I'd eaten. A mildly annoying conversation with a colleague. The weather, in tedious, granular detail, the kind of detail no one requests and no one usually wants. I did this because it occurred to me, sitting there listening to his breathing on the other end, that these were exactly the calls he used to make to me — the ones with no news in them at all, just company, just a voice filling a room. I understood, describing my own unremarkable Tuesday into his silence, that I was finally, belatedly, learning to make the kind of call he had been making to me for a decade, and that I had learned it only once he could no longer receive it the way it was intended.

And I told him, on the last call I remember clearly, that his grandson had said "dada" that week — not for me, for the boy's own father down the hall, a small ordinary miracle that happens in a million kitchens every single day and had never once, before that phone call, felt like something I needed my own father to witness. I said it into a silence so complete that the nurse, in the background, said again, gently, "he can hear you, keep going," and I understood, saying it a

second time in a slightly smaller voice, that I no longer fully believed her, and that I was going to keep talking anyway, because the alternative was hanging up on a father who was still, technically, alive to hang up on, and I could not make myself do that.

These calls left me hollowed out in a way that has no comparison in my life before them. It is a specific, particular exhaustion — the exhaustion of loving someone loudly into a silence, of performing an entire relationship alone, both halves of it, because one half has gone somewhere you cannot follow and cannot even properly picture. I would hang up and sit very still for a while afterward, in whatever room I happened to be in, on whatever continent, and feel something that was not quite grief yet, because he was still, in the most technical sense, here — feel instead something closer to a rehearsal for grief, a kind of practicing, my body quietly getting ready for a loss it somehow already understood was coming, even while the man himself was still, in a bed on the other side of the world, breathing.

Babak carried a different version of this weight, the version that comes from proximity rather than distance — the daily visits, the arrangements with the nurse, the small physical indignities of caregiving that I never had to witness firsthand and that he has still, even now, only described to me in fragments, as if the fuller account is something he's protecting me from, or perhaps protecting himself from by not saying it all out loud in one sitting. I think often about the asymmetry of what we each carried in those years — his exhaustion made of proximity, mine made of distance, neither one lighter than the other, both of us occasionally, privately, resentful of a weight we couldn't fully explain to someone standing in the other position. We have talked about this since, carefully, the way you talk about old wounds you've both mostly forgiven each other for, and I don't think either of us has fully resolved it. I don't think it's the kind of thing that resolves. I think it's just one more shape grief takes when it has to be split unevenly between two people who both loved the same failing man from two different distances.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

[INTERIOR IV]

Warm.

That is most of what is left, some days — not a scene, not a face, not even the folding-together of faces from before. Just warm, and something like being held, though held by what, or when, has stopped being a question that needs an answer.

There was a taste once. It is still, faintly, here — saffron, or something saffron-adjacent, a memory of a memory of a taste, arriving without the meal attached to it, without the table, without the hands that made it. It arrives the way a single note arrives after an entire song has otherwise gone quiet, and it is, in whatever way anything is still anything in here, good. It is the last good thing with a name he no longer needs in order to still recognize.

Somewhere, very far off, a voice is still occasionally shaped like love. He cannot tell anymore whose voice, or what it wants, or what year it thinks it's calling from. He does not need to. The shape is enough. The shape has always, in the end, been the entire point — not the words, not the specific news, not the specific son, just the fact of a voice bothering, still, to reach this far, to keep reaching even into whatever this has become.

He is warm, and something in the far distance still loves him, and there is a taste like saffron that asks nothing of him, and that, on the days there is anything left to call a day, is the whole of the world now, and it is, in its own reduced and merciful way, enough.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

[PRESENT]

His heart had been failing, quietly, for longer than any of us fully registered — two surgeries over the years, a pacemaker installed almost as an afterthought, the kind of thing you mention once and then stop mentioning because it becomes simply a fact about a person, like his height. I think, now, that the heart had been absorbing things for decades that had nowhere else to go — the marriage, the year he'd spent at his mother's bedside and everything that year had cost him afterward, the years of a house that stopped asking anything of him — and that a heart can only be asked to hold so much before it decides, quietly, on its own schedule, that it has held enough.

It happened in the early hours, in his sleep, in the house that had been the only place left for so long it had stopped being a retreat and simply become the last address. No struggle, as far as anyone could tell. No final crisis, no hospital corridor, no machines counting down anything for an audience. My mother, when I told her, said the only thing that made any sense to either of us: "That house finally let him go somewhere."

I got the call at an hour that would have been the middle of his afternoon and the deepest part of my night, and I understood, picking up the phone and seeing Babak's name before he'd said a single word, exactly what I was about to be told, the way you sometimes know the shape of a sentence half a second before its first word arrives.

The flight I booked that night was the same route I had booked a dozen times before, and I remember being struck, checking in at an hour when the airport was nearly empty, by how identical the whole mechanical process felt to every other trip — the same forms, the same security line, the same overpriced coffee I bought out of habit rather than desire — as if the airline's systems had no way of registering that this particular flight was different from all the ones that came before it. My wife offered to come with me. I told her to stay, to keep our son on his schedule, and I'm still not entirely sure whether that was consideration for her or a private wish to make this one leg of the journey without an audience, even a loving one. I spent most of the flight staring at the seatback in front of me, not sleeping, not really thinking either, in the specific suspended state grief puts you in before it's had time to arrange itself into anything as organized as thoughts.

I will not pretend the grief that followed was simple, and I will not pretend it looked the way grief looks in the stories we tell about it — a single wound, clean, understood. It looked, instead, like standing very still for a long time in a kitchen on the other side of the world, holding a phone that had gone silent, feeling several things at once that did not agree with each other: grief for the man in the photographs, thin and laughing, whom I had never once actually met; grief for the man on the Friday calls, thinning in a different way, whom I had loved without ever fully knowing; and underneath both of those, something that arrived later and quieter and took me longer to admit even to myself — something that was not relief, exactly, but was standing close enough to relief that for a long time I couldn't tell the two apart in the dark.

By the time I landed, Babak had already handled most of what needed handling — the paperwork, the arrangements, the specific bureaucratic weight of proving to various offices that a man had, in fact, died, that the death was expected, that no further explanation was owed to anyone beyond what the doctors had already provided. I have never fully told him how grateful I am for that, for absorbing the logistics so that what was left for me, arriving jet-lagged and hollow, was simply to grieve rather than to also administrate. We buried him three days later, faster than I would have liked and exactly as fast as custom required, in a plot near his mother's, close enough that I found myself thinking, standing at the graveside, that whatever argument had kept him tethered to her house for thirty years had, in the end, gotten its final wish: he would not be far from her, not now, not ever again.

His heart, in the end, did what nothing and no one else in his life had managed to do for him. It ended the waiting. It gave him — and I believe this, I have come to believe it fully, even though I did not want to believe it at first — the one mercy that was still available, after all the others had already been spent: a door that opened quietly, in his sleep, in the house that had held him at the end the way it had held his mother before him, with no one required to watch the leaving happen, no last argument, no last performance, nothing asked of him at all.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

[PRESENT]

At the graveside, an old man I didn't recognize took both my hands and said the phrase that everyone says, the one that means, more or less, *may he be forgiven, may he be at rest*. I had heard it a hundred times in my life, at other families' losses, and had always known exactly what to say back. It was a small, worn coin of a sentence, passed hand to hand, and you were supposed to hand it back with a nod and a word of your own.

I opened my mouth and found I had nothing to hand back. Not because I didn't believe it. Because I didn't know, anymore, what rest would even look like for a man who had spent his last years being slowly erased from the inside — whether the mercy was in the forgiveness or in the fact that there was, at last, nothing left in him that needed forgiving, or wanting, or remembering. I said "thank you," which was not an answer, and the old man patted my hands and moved on, satisfied, and I understood that most of the coin's value was in the shape of it, not the meaning, and that this was probably fine. That most of what people say at funerals is a shape.

It took months for the second thing to arrive, and when it did, it arrived quietly, on a Tuesday, while I was making my son's lunch.

I noticed that my stomach no longer tightened at four in the afternoon.

For two years, four o'clock had been a small, private siege. It was the hour I used to call, before the calls stopped meaning anything, and later it became the hour the nurse or my mother would call *me*, and my stomach had learned the sound of my own phone the way a soldier learns the sound of a particular engine. Bad news traveled at four o'clock. It had traveled at four o'clock so many times that my body had simply started arriving at the news before the news did.

And now it was a Tuesday, and it was four o'clock, and there was nothing. My son wanted more of the yellow cheese, not the white one, and I gave it to him, and somewhere in the giving I realized that the siege had ended, and that some part of me — some low, unlit, unphilosophical part — was *grateful*.

I stood very still with the cheese in my hand.

I thought: *what kind of son feels his shoulders come down after his father is buried*.

I turned the thought over the way you turn over a stone you don't want to see what's under, already knowing. Guilt arrived first, fast and total, the way it always does, telling me this was proof of something ugly in me, some deficiency that had been there all along and had finally been given permission to show itself now that no one could be hurt by it. I had read, once, somewhere, that this happens to people, this small shameful loosening, and had thought at the time: not me, I would never feel that, I love him too much for that. I had been wrong. Love, it turned out, had nothing to do with it, or everything to do with it, I couldn't tell which, and that not-knowing was its own kind of grief I hadn't been warned about.

Because underneath the guilt, when I made myself look, there wasn't relief that my father was gone. There was relief that the waiting was gone. The two were not the same animal, though they wore the same coat, and it had taken me months to tell them apart in the dark.

I still wanted the phone to ring. I wanted it so badly some nights that I'd hold my own phone in both hands like it might do something if I asked it kindly enough. I wanted, specifically, my father's voice — thinned out, slow, wrong in a dozen small ways by the end — saying my name the way he used to say it, stretched a little long, like he was buying himself a second to remember which son he was talking to. I wanted that voice so much it made my teeth hurt.

And in the same chest, at the same hour, I did not want to hear the other voice. The one that had replaced it. The one that said nothing back, or said something that belonged to no year and no memory either of us shared, or simply breathed against the receiver while a nurse in the background said *he can hear you, keep talking, he likes hearing you talk* — and I would keep talking, into that silence, telling a bed-bound stranger who had once been my father that his grandson had said his first word, that Babak had proposed, that the weather had been strange all week, and getting nothing back but breath. I did not think I could survive many more of those calls. I had said so, once, to my wife, at two in the morning, ashamed of the sentence even as it left me: *I don't know if I can keep doing this*. And then my father had done the one last, enormous kindness available to him, which was to stop needing anyone to keep doing it.

Grief was new to me. I wanted to say that in my own defense, to whoever was going to judge me for the unclenching in my shoulders — *I have never done this before, I don't have the customs for it, I am improvising a decency I was never taught*. Nobody had told me that you could love a person completely and be glad, in some wordless, disloyal cellar of yourself, that you would not have to watch them not know you anymore. Nobody had told me grief could come dressed as relief and still be grief, still be love, just love that had run out of anywhere useful to go.

I put the cheese away. My son said "dada" in the easy, unweighted way children say things that used to cost my father everything to hear near the end, and I picked him up and held him for longer than the moment required, because I had, finally, someone to practice on — someone whose face I would know completely, whose favorite song and favorite food and favorite place I intended, with something like ferocity, to always be able to name.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

[PRESENT]

I went back to the same room, months later, for a smaller gathering — a fortieth-day remembrance, quieter than the first, fewer strangers, more of the people who had actually known him. Nobody asked me for a favorite song this time. I think now that this is simply how it goes: the impossible questions get asked once, early, when everyone still believes there must be an answer somewhere, and then, once no answer arrives, people quietly agree not to ask again, the way you stop checking a pocket you've already searched twice.

Babak and I ended up outside, in the small paved courtyard behind the hall, doing what we always do now when we're together and the grief gets too crowded indoors — trading stories, the way we used to trade them as boys, except now the trading has a different weight to it, each story a small act of preservation rather than simple entertainment. He told me a version of the parking incident I hadn't heard before, an earlier one, from before I'd left, in which our father had apparently gone so far as to leave a note under the offending windshield wiper, then retrieved it ten minutes later out of what Babak assumed was embarrassment, and folded it into his pocket rather than delivering it, carrying the undelivered verdict around in his coat for the rest of the day like evidence of a crime only he knew about. I told him about the record player, the four unknown records, the neighbor's broom handle. Neither of us had heard the other's story before. This is, I think, one of the stranger mercies of losing a parent late rather than early — that there is still, even now, new material surfacing between the two of us who are left, small deposits of him we hadn't yet spent, and I suspect we'll keep finding them for years, the way you keep finding coins in the pockets of a coat you thought you'd emptied.

I found myself, near the end of the evening, standing again by the same photograph — the one from the first gathering, the good one, the one where my father was looking almost directly at whoever held the camera, an expression that wasn't quite a smile but wasn't far from one either. I looked at it for a long time.

I thought about the dervishes again, the image that had first arrived to me standing in an empty room full of nothing worth keeping. I had looked it up since then, the actual history of it, more than I'd known before — the turning as a discipline, a lifetime of practice aimed at a single goal, which was to arrive, eventually, at nothing: no possessions, no attachments, no self left standing between the person and whatever came next. I had thought, at the time, that my father's empty room only resembled that discipline by accident, by exhaustion rather than intention.

I'm not sure anymore that the distinction matters as much as I'd assumed.

Whatever the reasons — grief, or a marriage lost to other people's will, or a mother's death that took the last argument for leaving, or simply a temperament that had never accumulated much to begin with — my father had arrived, by the end, at a version of that same emptiness. A room with almost nothing in it. A heart that had finally been allowed to stop carrying what it had carried for so long. A mind that had, by whatever mercy or cruelty governs such things, forgotten the very griefs it had never been able to resolve while it still had the capacity to remember them. I do not know whether my father found any peace in that forgetting. I know only that from the outside, in the last months, there had been a stillness in his face that looked, at certain angles, almost like the calm of someone who had finally put something down.

I thought of it, standing in front of the photograph, as a doorway rather than an ending — not because I believe, particularly, in doorways, but because it was the only image that let me hold both halves of it at once: the son who wanted to keep him, and the son who understood, eventually, that the kindest thing left to want, for a man who had run out of quality of life long before he ran out of life, was for the door to finally open.

I did not cry at this gathering, the way I had at the first one. I stood for a while longer in front of the photograph, said nothing that anyone else could hear, and then went to find my brother, because there was, after everything, still a whole family left on this side of the door, and someone needed to ask what was for dinner.

EPILOGUE

[INTERIOR — SPECULATION]

Nobody can know what this was actually like from the inside, and this book has said so already, more than once. What follows is offered in that same spirit — not as claimed fact, but as the only kind of understanding still available to the people left holding the question.

There must have been alert moments, even near the end. Not many, and not for long, but the doctors said as much, gently, the way doctors learn to say things that are both a comfort and a warning at once: that recognition can flicker back briefly, unpredictably, like a signal catching a tower it had drifted out of range of. On those moments, if they happened the way we hope they happened, I like to imagine it was something like surfacing — not confusion clearing all at once, but a single window opening in a house otherwise gone dark, just long enough to feel warmth arrive through it before it closed again. A voice saying his name. A hand that felt like it belonged to someone. Perhaps, for a few seconds, something almost like *being* him again — not enough to organize a sentence, not enough to reach for the phone himself, but enough, maybe, to feel loved without needing to understand exactly why, or by whom, or for how long that feeling might last before the window shut.

I hope, in those moments, that what reached him wasn't the news itself — not the specific fact of a wedding, or a first step, or a grandson's first word — but the tone underneath the news, the register of a voice trying, across an impossible distance, to hand him something good. I think tone might survive longer than meaning does. I have to believe that, because it's the only version of those one-sided phone calls I can live with: that some current of *this is good, this is joy, this is us wanting you here for it* got through, even on the calls where nothing in his face moved at all.

And there must have been the other moments too — many more of them, by the end, than the alert ones — the ones the illness itself made, the long stretches where nothing organized enough to call a thought was happening at all. I don't think this was darkness, exactly, though it would be easy to assume so from outside a hospital bed. Darkness requires a boundary, an edge you can sense yourself pressed against. I think it might have been closer to what a candle experiences between being lit — not suffering, not absence exactly, just an interval with no experiencer present to suffer through it. Time, if it existed for him at all in those stretches, might not have passed the way it passes for the rest of us, second stacked on second. It might have simply not been happening, the way it isn't happening for a stone, or for the year 1962, or for any of the countless hours of our own lives we've already forgotten completely without ever once mourning the loss of them.

That thought used to frighten me. It doesn't anymore, or not in the same way. Because if that's true — if those long stretches truly were closer to nothing than to suffering — then some of what looked, from our side of the phone, like the cruelest possible ending, may have been, from his side, no ending at all. Just an absence with no one inside it left to be afraid of the dark.

A chair. Warm light through fabric. A smell that might be saffron, or might only be the memory of a memory of it.

And then, simply, a door — unremarkable, unhurried, standing very slightly open, the way a door stands open in a house where someone is expected home any minute.

He goes through it.

Nothing comes back to tell us, with certainty, which of these it was — the surfacing or the stone, the window or the interval with no one behind it. Perhaps, at the very end, it was neither, and simply became, for the first time in years, entirely his own business again.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR



A man sits at his father's memorial and realizes he cannot name the three simple things everyone expects a son to know. *He loved the man. But did he know him?*

A STRANGER'S FAVORITE SONG is a novella about the long distance between closeness and understanding—and the cost of waiting too late to cross it.

From a marriage that ended under family pressure to a father slowly vanishing to Alzheimer's. From small routines and stubborn habits to jokes that took a decade to come true. It is the story of losing someone twice: once to forgetting, and once to death.

This book is not about perfect fathers or perfect sons. It is about the small, awkward, ordinary attempts we make to reach each other—and the mercy of understanding, even when it arrives too late to use.

**YOU THINK YOU KNOW THE PEOPLE YOU LOVE.
THIS BOOK WILL MAKE YOU QUESTION
EVERY MEMORY OF THEM.**

